

Waiting in the wings

India's next generation of track and field athletes showed their potential in Eugene, returning with three medals and **plenty of promise.**

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Global recognition matters a lot for a young track and field athlete. An early taste of success can be a huge motivation for the rest of their career. From an Indian perspective, the biggest example is Neeraj Chopra.

Neeraj put his name among the next generation of javelin stars when he became Junior World Champion in Bydgoszcz, Poland, in 2016 with a World U-20 Record, which remains unbroken. Since then, the poster boy of Indian athletics has added every possible global title to his collection.

A knock-on effect of Neeraj's heroics has been the added Indian interest in every edition of the World Athletics U-20 Championships since. The recent meet, held from August 5-9 at Hayward Field in Eugene, Oregon, was no different.

The Athletics Federation of India had sent a 36-member contingent to compete with the best juniors from around the globe. The squad featured some very talented athletes such as high jumper Pooja Singh, the reigning Asian Champion who broke the senior National Record this year, and long jumper Shahnava Khan (**left**) who has a Personal Best of 8.30m.

Out of 46 events, India competed in 19. Apart from Nitin Gupta, who finished sixth in a direct final for the men's 5000m race walk crown, eight other individuals as well as the women's 4x400m relay quartet qualified for the medal round. The list of finalists could have been slightly longer if the likes of Nishchay

